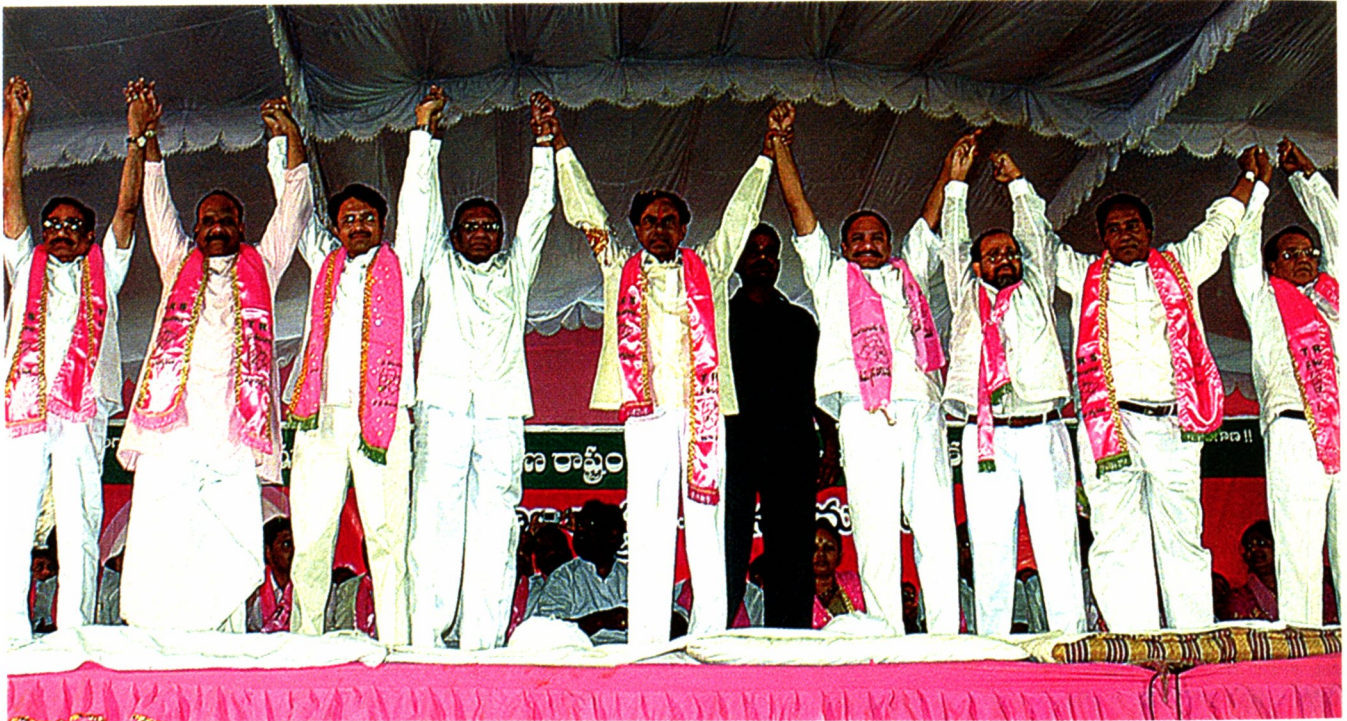


THE QUIT FIX

By resigning en masse, TRS MPs and MLAs hope to force the UPA's hand on Telangana, turning the spotlight on the divisive issue once again

Photographs by A PRABHAKAR RAO



■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Twenty-three Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) legislators, including acerbic party supremo K. Chandrasekhara Rao, resigned from the Lok Sabha and state assembly on March 3, bringing to a head their protracted battle for a separate state of Telangana. While the mass resignation has put the Congress on the defensive regarding the bifurcation of the 51-year-old state, it is a new beginning for TRS.

Rao built the campaign up tactfully. Starting with a day-long rally at Jantar Mantar in Delhi that included the 23 representatives—four from the Lok Sabha, 16 from the state legislative assembly and three from the state legislative council—the protest was followed by the resignations, first from the Lok Sabha and then the two houses of the state legislature.

The resignations have given renewed momentum to the demand for separate statehood for the Telangana region, which comprises 10 districts, including Hyderabad. What

TRS has also succeeded in doing is applying democratic pressure on the Congress at the Centre, without taking the battle to the streets. They are hopeful that the UPA Government will finally comply with what it had assured in its manifesto ahead of the 2004 election and in the inaugural address of the President to the current Lok Sabha. Criticising Congress President Sonia Gandhi, the TRS supremo accuses the party of ditching the Telangana issue after coming to power. Says Rao, "We have been betrayed by the Congress. We want to mobilise the people and intensify our struggle."

Isolated from the Congress, TRS is eager to step up what may ultimately become a no-holds barred campaign to achieve statehood. Their gameplan is to visit every village in the Telangana region to create awareness for their cause and mobilise support for it.

RESOLUTE: Rao (centre) hopes to pressure the Congress

Says G. Vijayarama Rao, TRS leader in the legislative assembly, "We remained mute spectators as Congress continued to mete out injustice to the region in the past four years."

It is not just the Congress which the party is criticising. It plans to point out how TDP and CPI(M) have historically opposed the carving out of the state. The party is upbeat about the resignation strategy paying off with increased support from students and the youth. At the same time, it is being careful

about keeping the campaign non-violent as violence may ultimately dilute their cause. The outlawed Maoists, who have pledged support to TRS, have warned that they will teach a lesson to those parties which are opposed to a separate state.

Rao asserts that the resignations will

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